important political, social and economic force (Hiller 2000). Sport also plays an important cultural or cultural-hegemonic role. It can be used, or abused, to strengthen national identities. These different roles of sport are played out in powerful ways in the mega-sports events (Tomlinson and Young 2006). The official slogan of the 2014 Brazil World Cup was 'All in one rhythm'. According to the web pages of FIFA, the Slogan is more than a tagline. 'It represents the underlying mindset and theme running through all aspects of the tournament organisation … Brazilians are invited to join together and celebrate the immense sense of pride in their country's position on the global stage and their role as hosts of the 2014 FIFA World Cup.'[1] The 2016 Olympics slogan is 'Live your passion'. These slogans capture the powerful sentiments that sports embody.

Broken promises

What was observed in South Africa in connection with the FIFA 2010 World Cup can be expected on an even larger scale in Brazil. The many delays, budgets exceeded, corruption scandals, and human and civil rights abuses that have plagued the construction works in Rio de Janeiro have already led to a sobering-up process. Growing numbers of people are questioning the true intentions of the authorities and the ultimate consequences for ordinary residents.

In spite of a decade of economic growth and poverty reduction under the PT administrations, Brazilian cities still have the dubious reputation of being the world's most unequal. People's increased income has enabled the growth of consumption. It has, however, not automatically resulted in an improved quality of life, as indicators of crime, violence and levels of education and health remain poor. Neither has it addressed the socio-spatial segregation that characterises cities such as Rio de Janeiro. According to the Brazilian Institute of Geography and Statistics (IBGE), 22% of the population of Rio de Janeiro lived in favelas in 2010. While not all living in the favelas are poor, a range of socio-economic, political, racial and cultural markers still work to exclude favela residents from many of the citizen rights enjoyed by residents of the formal city – what Holston (2007) has termed 'differentiated citizenship'. With the preparations for the mega-events, these differences are becoming more evident.

Carlos Vainer (2011) argues that the preparations for the mega-events have authorised, consolidated and legalised practices of legal exception in order to abide by the demands of private sponsors and the organising committees. The forms of illegality and exceptions to the institutional order have been multiplied, making Rio a city of permanent exception. Contracts and case-by-case negotiations have become more important than the law, and bargaining power has more weight